STATE SCAN

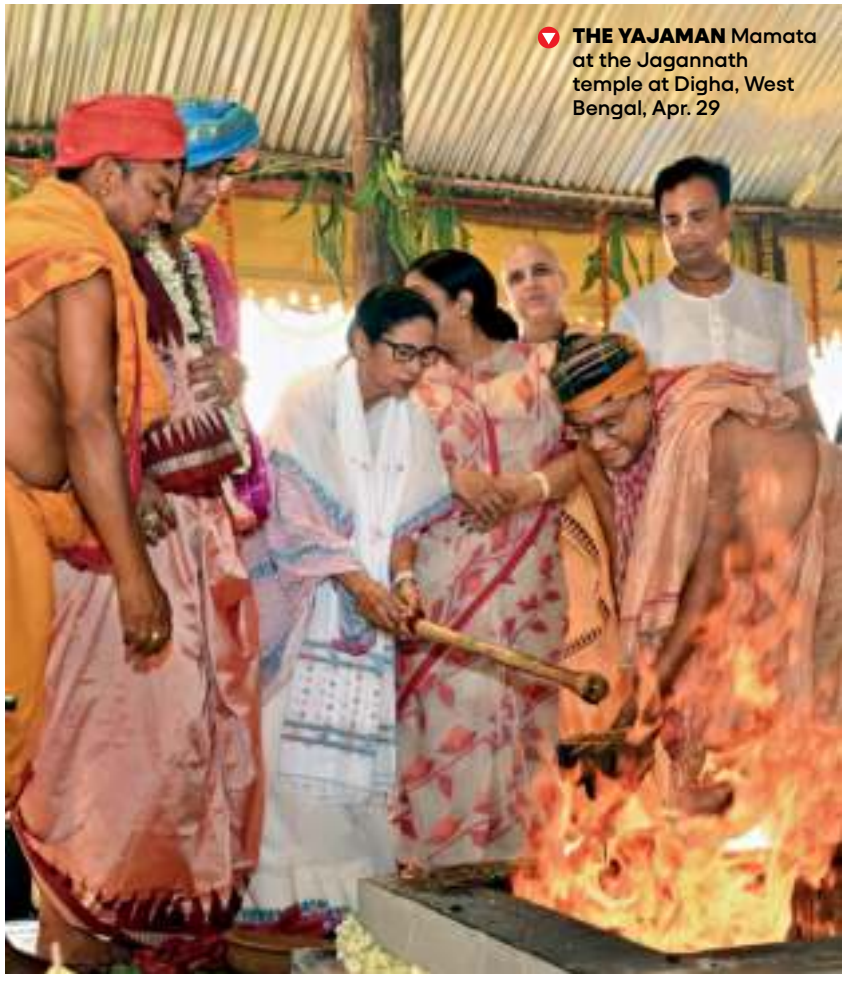
MAHARASHTRA: CEASEFIRE IN PAWAR LAND? *PG 16* | **KERALA:** 'MOLLY' GOES ZUMBA *PG 18*

▶ WEST BENGAL

MAMATA'S HINDU AVATAR

Competitive Hinduism comes to rule in West Bengal, as Mamata Banerjee seeks to negate the BJP's USP—and maybe wash off old sins—with a new Jagannath temple

By **Arkamoy Datta Majumdar**



THE YAJAMAN Mamata at the Jagannath temple at Digha, West Bengal, Apr. 29

IN WINDSWEPT DIGHA, beneath the searing April sun, there stood Mamata Banerjee with folded hands. Climbing the 210-foot-tall spire with the sacred flag, for the final act of a long-awaited consecration, were two servitors from Puri. Their presence conferred sanctity upon this shiny new epigone of the Jagannath temple. A day later, April 30, the public would stream in, some 200,000 of them, rising to 500,000 the next day. But today, West Bengal's chief minister was a deity unto herself. Playing yajaman with gravitas, the role enacted by Prime Minister Narendra Modi at Ayodhya, ensuring she was the cynosure of all eyes.

The act was live-streamed to every corner of the state, by her state administration as well as her party, the Trinamool Congress (TMC). Hoardings reprised the BJP's "after a thousand years" phraseology. Prasad (and photos of the temple) will be distributed to every household in Bengal—an exact echo of the RSS's mass outreach post Ayodhya. Lord Jagannath, or his divine alter ego, had clearly been wheeled all the way from Puri, 300-odd km down the coast in Odisha, with a purpose. Salvation not in the hereafter, but here and now.

POLITICAL JUGGERNAUT

Often pilloried for 'anti-Hindu' politics, Mamata has made her most conspicuous embrace yet of Hindu symbolism with this mega spectacle. The moment was not merely ceremonial. It was a declaration. Previously content with letting TMC satraps partake of local rituals, or sponsoring Durga puja pandals, Mamata has now sallied forth directly into the domain of mass devotion. The ground was prepared with public assertions of her Brahminical identity. Now, Mamata is eminently capable of